was a serious problem during the 1960s and early 1970s, and women often gave up their jobs so they could queue for food."[25]

Workplaces and schools began to provide lunch, the main meal of the day, in an effort to equalize access and diminish some of the burden on women. The government also introduced "Plan Jaba" or the Shopping Bag Plan in 1971. In families where all of the adults worked, they would receive a special stamp in their ration book allowing a family member to simply drop off their shopping bag on the way to work, and pick it up, filled, at the end of the day – thus avoiding the long line.

As in the case of race, the economic crisis of the 1990s recreated some of the pre-revolutionary inequalities that the revolution had worked so hard to overcome (see Chapter 7).

Sexuality

The Revolution made an early and explicit commitment to eliminating race and gender inequality. There was no such commitment in the area of sexual orientation. On the contrary. In the first decade of the Revolution the (heterosexual) nuclear family was clearly defined as the essential unit of society, and non-heterosexual activity and relationships explicitly proscribed.

As numerous studies of sexuality and sexual orientation in Latin America have shown, the dichotomy currently common in the United States and Europe between "heterosexual" and "homosexual" is a cultural construction. In other cultural and historical contexts, different categories and distinctions prevail. While same-sex sexual activity has existed in all times and places, the idea that individuals possess a "sexual orientation" towards members of the same, or the opposite, sex, is culturally and historically specific. In Europe and the United States, it dates to the late nineteenth century. Prior to this time, while the existence of same-sex sexual activity was widely recognized, it was not seen as constituting an identity or a sexual orientation. Identifying sexual orientation as such, in fact, was part of pathologizing it.[26]